Playing Scrabble with Eddie

By Taylor Mali

INTRODUCTION

Taylor Mali spent nine years teaching English, history, and math, including stints at Browning School, a boys school on the Upper East Side of New York City, and Cape Cod Academy, a K-12 private school on Cape Cod, Massachusetts. He now lectures and conducts workshops for teachers and students all over the world. In 2001 Taylor Mali used a grant from the New York Foundation for the Arts to develop the one-man show "Teacher! Teacher!" about poetry, teaching, and math. He is a strong advocate for the nobility of teaching and in 2000 he set out to create 1,000 new teachers through "poetry, persuasion, perseverance, or passion." As of June 1, 2009, he has 335.

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Despite his dyslexia or perhaps because of it,
Eddie can beat every other eighth grader in Scrabble.
Kick their asses in fact, and he knows it,
though he can't say it, at least not in those words,
because if he said "ass" in my eight grade
I'd give him a detention on the spot.

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Scrabble was made for his mind.
Show him a rack of seven letters,
he'll tell you in an instant 10 different words
that use some combination of those letters,
his mind hard-wired for confusion,
for discombobulating vowels
and the jangling clangor of consonants.
But ask him to spell those 10 words,
and he may DARE to READ DEAR
when the word READS DREAD.

Combine dyslexia with hyperactivity,
which now we call A.D.D.,
Attention Deficit Disorder,--
though Eddie says impishly, D.D.A.!--
fifteen milligrams of Ritalin taken twice a day,
dispensed by the nurse, an IQ of 165
and all the hormones of a 13-year-old boy
just dying for an education, and you have yourself
one horny, whacked-out, eight-grade genius
staring at the seven tiles on his rack

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as if getting the letters in the right order
would unlock all the secrets of the language.

Eddie stares at my face, at the board, at his rack,
at his rack, at the board, at my face.
And I wonder what his dyslexic, rearranging mind
is doing with my eyes & my ears & my nose.
How many one-eyed, Picasso-faced English teachers
are staring back at him from the educated
audience of his adolescence?
How many monsters can he spell with my face?
But here comes the word:

K-C-U-F

Kcuf? Eddie, I think I'm going to have to
challenge you on that word.

And Eddie reddens. Eddie reddens
like he finally got the punch line to a dirty Joke,
which in a way he has. Eddie reddens
like I've finally caught him swearing,
which in a way I haven't. Yet.

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And the letters pivot around the K.

C-U-F

Oh. Well, that's different.

"Is that OK, Mr. Mali?"

Is that okay!? Is that okay, Eddie!?
You landed the F on a Double Letter square
and the K on a Double Word--
That's 34 points, young man!

"Hot shit!" says Eddie.

And I give him a detention on the spot.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
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